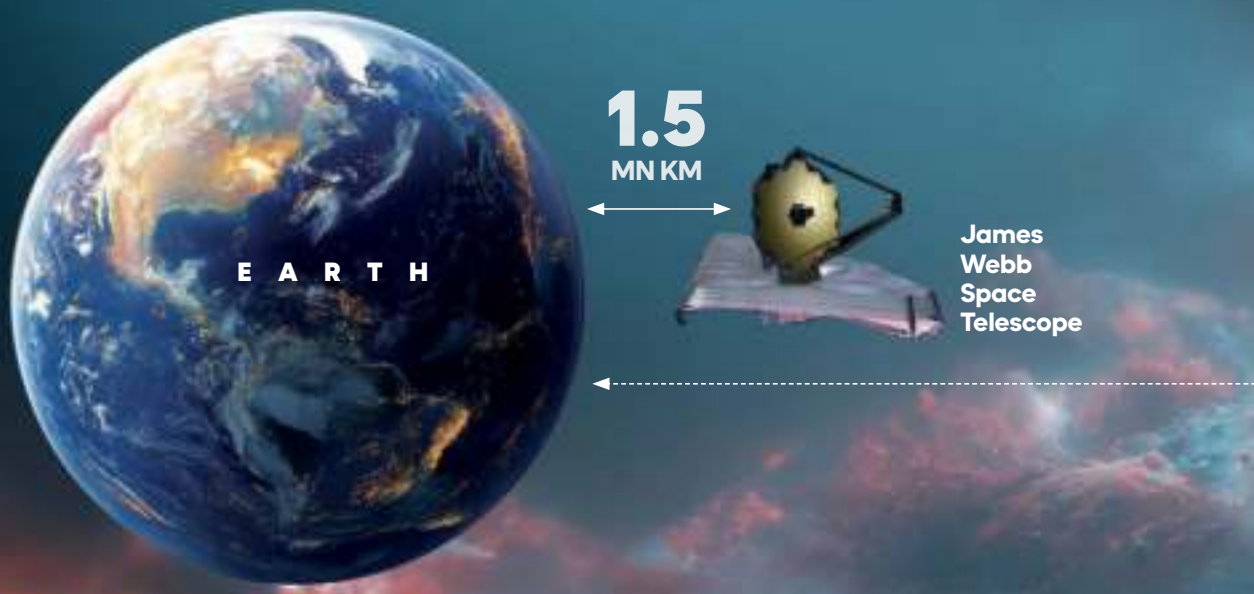
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ANYBODY OUT THERE?

Bubbling up in ancient Greek theories and medieval speculations, the quest for 'aliens' or extraterrestrial life finally acquired...well, a life of its own with modern sci-fi. The most exciting piece of evidence that the fantasy may indeed be reality has only come now: with the hint of a 'bio-signature' on a distant planet, discovered by a Cambridge team led by Nikku Madhusudhan, a scientist of Indian origin, and published in *the Astrophysical Journal Letters* this April

Graphic by **NILANJAN DAS** / Text by **AJAY SUKUMARAN**



THE DISCOVERER AND HIS THOUGHTS



NIKKU MADHUSUDHAN

Professor of Astrophysics and Exoplanetary Science Institute of Astronomy, University of Cambridge. Born in India in 1980, Nikku Madhusudan graduated with a BTech from IIT-BHU in 2002, before pursuing a master's and PhD at MIT

"For the first time in the history of our species, we may actually be seeing signs of life elsewhere"

"This could also be a signal of a new chemical process not produced by life. Even that is a monumental breakthrough because we are seeing (it) on a planet that could be habitable"

"We should remain open-minded and get more observations so that we can repeat this signal. That's the hallmark of science, the repeatability and increase in robustness till we are really, really satisfied. We are not there yet"